



Partly sunny 51/46 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 59/37 B20

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, JANUARY 6, 2026 • \$4

Walz ends run for a third term in Minn.

Governor faces intense scrutiny amid probes of welfare fraud in his state

BY HANNAH KNOWLES,
DAN MERICA
AND THEODORIC MEYER

Democratic Gov. Tim Walz said Monday he is dropping his bid for reelection in Minnesota, a dramatic turn for the two-term governor who gained national prominence as his party's 2024 vice-presidential nominee but now faces intense scrutiny over welfare fraud investigations in his state.

Sen. Amy Klobuchar (D-Minnesota) is considering jumping into the governor's race in his stead, according to two people familiar with the matter who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private conversations. One person said Klobuchar is "almost certain" to run and met with Walz on Sunday. The other said Klobuchar has not made a final decision.

Walz's decision marks a striking political fall for a staunch liberal who was tapped as Kamala Harris's running mate in 2024 and viewed as a potential presidential candidate in 2028. Democrats had grown increasingly worried about Walz's choice to seek a third term as Republicans, including President Donald Trump, put a spotlight on the growing fraud probe, which federal prosecutors initiated several years ago.

GOP influencers, a viral video and new information from authorities — who say the scams could be far bigger than previously known and reach into the

SEE WALZ ON A7

In N.Y. court, Maduro says U.S. 'kidnapped' him



ADAM GRAY/REUTERS

Law enforcement officials escort deposited Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro and his wife, Cilia Flores, to a New York court Monday.

Trump and Rubio have their sights set on Cuba

BY KAREN DEYOUNG
AND DAVID OVALLE

No place was hit harder than Cuba by the shock waves that Saturday morning's U.S. military seizure of Venezuela's Nicolás Maduro sent throughout Latin America and the world.

Within hours of the operation — long before the government in Havana acknowledged it — phone calls and texts across the island spread the news that dozens of elite Cuban security forces had

Without Venezuela's aid, communist government will fall, they suggest

been killed guarding Maduro.

But by the time it finally released a statement late Sunday saying that 32 of its military and security personnel were dead in Caracas, the Cuban government had bigger problems on its hands.

Both President Donald Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio made clear over the weekend that the collapse of Cuba's communist government was not only a likely side benefit of Maduro's ouster but a goal.

"I don't think we need [to take] any action," Trump said as he flew back to Washington from his extended Florida holiday break. Without Maduro and the oil supplies Venezuela provided, he said, "Cuba looks like it's ready to fall." Rubio went further, indicating

that the United States might be willing to give it a push. "I'm not going to talk to you about what our future steps are going to be," he told NBC's "Meet the Press" on Sunday. But, he added, "If I lived in Havana and I was in the government, I'd be concerned."

Their words resonated with many in the Miami-centered exile community, where the struggle to free Cuba from communist rule has dominated politics for decades. On Saturday, South Florida

SEE CUBA ON A5

DEPOSED LEADER PLEADS NOT GUILTY

Venezuelan strongman faces drug, gun charges

BY SHAYNA JACOBS,
TIM CRAIG
AND MARK BERMAN

NEW YORK — Deposed Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro made his first court appearance Monday in New York and said he was "kidnapped" by the U.S. government, assailing the Trump administration for capturing him and portraying himself as his country's rightful leader.

The brief court proceedings in downtown Manhattan offered the first public opportunity for Maduro to speak since he and his wife, Cilia Flores, were seized by U.S. forces Saturday in Caracas. The nighttime raid, which followed months of escalating U.S. pressure on Maduro, set off shock waves across the globe, provoked confusion in Venezuela about that nation's leadership and prompted fears that President Donald Trump could act on threats he has made to other countries, including Cuba, Colombia and Canada.

For Maduro and Flores, Monday's hearing was the first step in what is likely to be a drawn-out legal process, one that Maduro's attorney expects will be "voluminous and complicated."

An indictment unsealed after their capture alleged that Maduro "sits atop a corrupt, illegitimate government that, for decades, has leveraged government power to protect and promote illegal activity, including drug trafficking." The indictment said Maduro has "remained in power despite losses in recent elections," and accused him, his wife and others in

SEE MADURO ON A4

Rodríguez: Venezuela's acting leader is seen as pragmatic. A16

Photos: A funeral, a swearing-in and more scenes from Caracas. A17



VALERIE PLESCH/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Nathan Tate, a former police officer, teaches a social studies class at Phoenix International School of the Arts in La Plata, Maryland.

Lesson on Jan. 6 is personal for D.C. cop turned teacher

BY ELLIE SILVERMAN

Nathan Tate had told almost no one about that day five years ago. He worried people might not believe him. Or they'd think he sounded weak. Or Tate would laugh, because that's what he does when he's nervous, even though nothing about Jan. 6 was funny to him.

Looking out at his classroom of 23 middle-schoolers — kids shifting in their seats and doodling in their workbooks — he wasn't sure what they already knew. They were third-graders in 2021. This lesson could be the first time they heard about it from someone they trusted.

"Let's talk," the social studies

teacher said.

In the unraveling narrative of Jan. 6, 2021, so many people claim to know the truth: The rioters who say they were protesting a stolen election. Republican leaders who have recast members of the violent mob as patriots. The quarter of Americans who say it is "probably" or "definitely" true that the FBI instigated the attack. The president who called it a "day of love."

Here in his classroom, nearly 250 years after the birth of American democracy, Tate wondered if he had the power to persuade a room of teenagers to reject all that.

He chose his words carefully.

SEE TEACHER ON A8

Across the nation, risk of disease is rising

BY LAUREN WEBER,
CAITLIN GILBERT,
DYLAN MORIARTY
AND JOSHUA LOTT

BECKER, MINNESOTA — Vaccination rates among kindergarten students have plunged across broad swaths of the United States since before the pandemic, exposing children and families to increasing health risks as many school districts pull back from their traditional role as a bulwark against infectious disease, according to a Washington Post investigation.

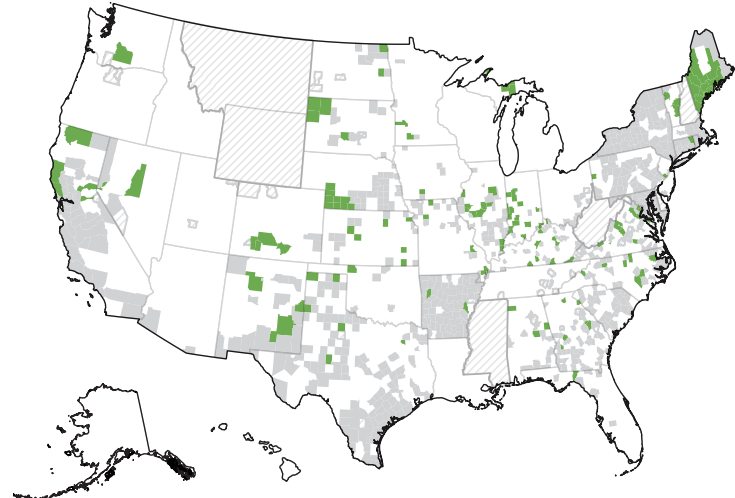
The accelerating decline reveals the lasting medical consequences of a political backlash against public health efforts during the pandemic, which radicalized many against long-standing vaccine mandates.

The share of U.S. counties where 95 percent or more of kindergarten students were vaccinated against measles — the number doctors say is needed to achieve overall protection for the class, known as "herd immunity" — has dropped from 50 percent before the pandemic to 28 percent, according to The Post's examination of the public records from 44 states and the District of Columbia.

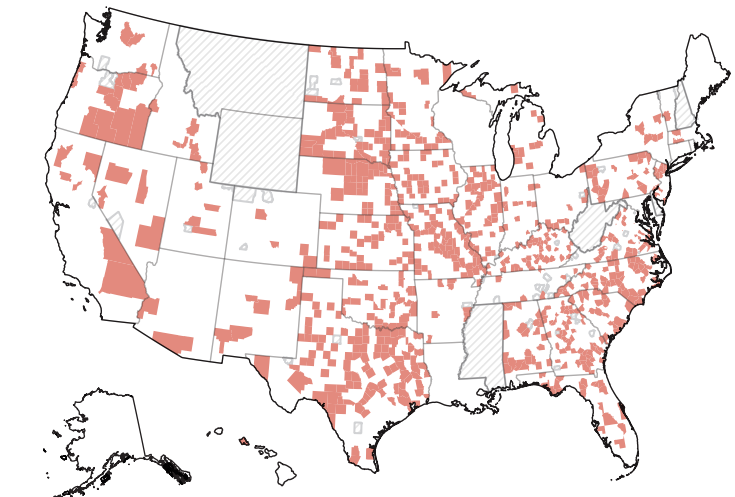
SEE VACCINES ON A10

Counties that maintained or gained herd immunity status post-pandemic

No data



Counties that lost herd immunity status post-pandemic



Source: Data collected or calculated by The Post

U.S. upends childhood vaccination schedule

BY LENA H. SUN AND
PAIGE WINFIELD
CUNNINGHAM

The Trump administration is overhauling the list of routine shots recommended for all babies and children in the United States, bypassing the government's typical process for recommending vaccines and delivering on Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s long-standing goals to upend the nation's pediatric vaccine schedule.

Effective immediately, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention will no longer recommend every child be immunized for rotavirus, influenza, meningococcal disease and hepatitis A, according to materials released Monday by the Department of Health and Human Services. Instead, the agency will recommend smaller groups of children and babies should get those vaccines only if they are at high risk or if a doctor recommends it.

Administration health officials said they were aligning U.S. recommendations more closely with vaccine schedules in other countries, citing decreased public confidence in vaccinations, especially following the covid-19 pandemic. Officials said the change would improve public trust in the vaccine

SEE VACCINE SCHEDULE ON A13

IN THE NEWS

Hegseth targets Kelly The defense secretary formally censured the Democratic senator and launched proceedings to consider whether to reduce his Navy rank in retirement. A3

Sea-level risks Samples from Greenland show a mountain of ice had melted in the past 10,000 years — and could do so again. A2

THE NATION
Plans drafted by the Department of Homeland Security outline drastic cuts to the Federal Emergency Management Agency workforce, including roles focused on disaster response. A3

THE WORLD
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A French court convicted 10 people of cyberbullying the nation's first lady. A16

THE ECONOMY
The first GLP-1 weight-loss pill is now available at pharmacies and via telehealth services. A20

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Broadway critics and industry insiders tend to follow an unwritten rule: Stroll a safe distance away before disparaging a show. B1

Stephen Schwartz, the composer of "Wicked," is the latest artist to back out of an engagement at the Kennedy Center. B1

SPORTS
Commanders QB Jayden Daniels plans to spend the offseason focusing on ways to stay healthy in 2026. B7

Black Monday in the NFL brings major changes, including Pete Carroll's exit after just one year in Las Vegas. B7

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